

PTA Technology Infrastructure

Primer and Use

draft work in process

Introduction and Background

The Montclair PTA Council and the PTAs that it supports provide several technology platforms to facilitate the operations of the PTAs. The primary platforms are Wordpress, Givebacks and Google Workspace.

A technology committee was started in the summer of 2025; it grew out of a need to update the website software identified in March 2025. This group collectively supports the infrastructure and there is representation from each PTA on this committee. The committee meets monthly to address concerns and opportunities. The 6 main concerns for 2025/26 are outlined in in a [document](#) and are:

1. Data Management/Security Improvement
2. Calendar integration
3. Streamlining processes and improving tools
 - includes liaison with the district IT group for Genesis data
 - as well as ad-hoc district support as in the case of mVps
4. Multisite training and support
5. Enhanced On-boarding of new PTA members (tools, training, processes)
6. Tech Committee role is as tech advocates, liaisons and change agents

There is a calendar for monthly meetings that is identified in the [list of important calendars](#) as “PTA Technology Committee.” One can view or subscribe to this and other calendar(s).

There is a [folder](#) on the PTAC google workspace to house important documents to this technology committee. This includes videos for training as well as other documents such as this one.

Technology support is available via an email group - technologycommittee@montclairpta.org that responds. Notably this is also a place where conversations are captured as individuals move off and onto this committee. Maintaining conversation history allows for new people to come up to speed on issues' history.

A brief description of the main technology platforms and their purpose follows:

- **Givebacks**
 - Corporate Compliance - Givebacks is required by NJ PTA. It helps assure each PTA's non-profit corporate compliance by collecting and storing Tax information/forms, officer contacts, bylaws, standing rules and the like.
 - Website - this is available but unused - the PTAs use Wordpress/Beaver Builder

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- Membership - It is the repository for PTA membership information and collection of dues via STRIPE. Note you can accept payments through other means like Zelle or a check for example but these collections are outside of Givebacks and you. Note that there are NJPTA dues per member and most PTAs (only president and treasurer have this visibility) just have this deducted from member dues.
 - Be sure that your Wordpress website has a link to join the PTA and that is directed to your store with membership as an item in it. This is often included in newsletters as well.
 - Store - since membership is purchased via GB, they make available a store feature that is available for other items like Spirit wear. Here is an [example](#) store; you can add items to this store from the Givebacks console. In Givebacks there are training videos, seminars and the like to assist you with this.
 - Marketing Communication Development and Distribution - Newsletter emails are the primary example of the use in the Montclair PTAs. Some PTAs send full weekly newsletters, others combine communications with the school principal and others send a summary and link to the website for their full story.
 - Rudimentary list management - Uploading and downloading of lists but no query or data management tools for the data held. No Deduping across lists for example. It does, however, provide Unsubscribe management for distributions within the platform. There is no native ability to upload and integrate unsubscribes from other platforms. Nonetheless it likely can be done and here is a [document](#) about it.
 - Platform tech support and training - there is a significant repository of support documents, video training as well as an AI bot to assist with support on this platform. So in this document we will elaborate no further.
- Wordpress - Multisite
 - This is not to be confused with the school's website which is managed by the school district and while there are common interests between the PTA and the school they are completely separate entities
 - Provides a unified look and feel across the 11 PTAs within the Montclair PTA Council. There is considerable latitude in presenting the "personality" of each of the magnet schools while also having a common header/footer look and top level navigation across the PTA sites allows parents with kids in multiple schools to learn a single navigation for the PTAs. As kids "age out" of schools and move to new ones, so do the volunteers that support the PTAs so having the same tools set across the PTAs makes usage and management easier.

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- Calendars are sharable across the PTA's - Note that the School District has websites as well that are entirely separate from the PTAs but school calendars are also displayable on each PTA website. The reverse however, is not the case.
- Wordpress is the chosen platform primarily because it was established and met the requirements, it was low cost, it is the singularly most deployed content management system in the USA.
 - The challenge was that there was never training on it made available.
 - While it may initially seem daunting, this truly is an illusion for nearly all functions required of the PTAs. This document will attempt to make this apparent.
 - The overall intent is to create an opportunity for all PTA communications to be housed in and accessible on the website and from there to share information to all other locations - this philosophy is called [POSSE](#) or Publish (on your) Own Site, Syndicate Elsewhere.
- Google Workspace
 - There are several different Google Workspaces across the PTAs - not to be confused with any school related resources provided by the school district like Genesis or Google classroom.
 - Google Workspace provides email, shared storage space and Google tools.
 - Domain registration and DNS are managed via Cloudflare or soon will be. This is paid by and done by PTAC for all PTA domains
 - The following domains are administered as described but are separate from the PTAC workspace

Bullock - bullockpta.org	Andrew, Mike and Sarah are admins a/o 12/22/25; previously unmanaged
Buzz - buzzaldrinpta.org	Andrew Manages it outside our Google Workspace. PTA pres also is admin but its unclear she knows she is the admin
Edgemont - edgemontpta.org	Managed by Chad; Rich is also an admin and does look at it
Hillside - hillsidepta.org	Andrew, Mike and president are admins a/o Jan 2026;
MHS - mhssat.org	mhssat.org ; points to MHS site and we are searching for someone to own the domain or for it to be deleted per Linda

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Nishuane - nishuanepta.org

Andrew Manages it outside our Google Workspace. Other admins are
- recsecy
- ptapres
- exptreasurer (the "exp" stands for "Explorers", their ASE program)
but they seem unaware of that role

- The domains that are administered through the main PTAC workspace are as follows. Note that montclairspecialed.org is not a PTA but PTAC nonetheless supplies GoogleWorkspace to them:
 - montclairpta.org
 - montclairpta.org
 - bradfordpta.org
 - glenfieldpta.org
 - mhs-pta.org
 - NortheastPTA.org
 - renaissancepta.org
 - WatchungPTA.org
 - montclairspecialed.org

● Other Tools in Use

External Tool	Function	PTA platform tool
Canva	Graphics, flyers, etc.	None
WhatsAPP, SMS	Real time chat	Google Chat
ZOOM	Virtual events	Google meet
Zelle, PayPal, ApplePal - add more here	money collection	Stripe (setup in GB)
Cheddar Up, Eventbrite, Signup Genius	Event management	none
MailChimp	Email Distribution	GMAIL
Tally, JotForm	Forms	Google Forms

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	List management	Google Sheets; GB
Instagram, Facebook	Social Media	Wordpress has (sassy social) buttons to share content to social media

Givebacks - Transition/Onboarding

As described above, this resource has commercial level support and is well documented so what is in the introduction.

Transition as new people come into their office roles. This boils down to

1. Entering in new officers and their contact information on 7/1 – note that GB wipes out this data annually.
 - a. Using your PTA managed email address as opposed to a personal email is recommended for security reasons
 - b. Note that there can only be one Treasurer and one President; even if you share the role with another person one must be chosen as the responsible party and the other given another title. You can have many Vice Presidents, for example.
2. Review and refreshing logins - remove privileges for people no longer involved. Maintain at least logins for the President, Treasurer and one technology focused person. There is a wide array of privileges settings but these 3 roles should have full admin rights. Other roles like Event manager or volunteers for an event should have differentiated levels of access; granting the minimum necessary to accomplish their role. If someone is doing only point of sale activity, grant them that access only.
3. Double check banking information is accurate
4. Purging any Genesis data (student information) that may have been loaded from the prior year(s)

Website

The PTA Council provides website services through a Wordpress Multisite running a custom Beaver Builder page editor. Login credentials are shared with representative(s) from each PTA. This is typically people with the role of Webmaster, Corresponding Secretary and President. Note that these are separate from credentials for:

- Google Workspace
- Givebacks

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- MPS District Calendars

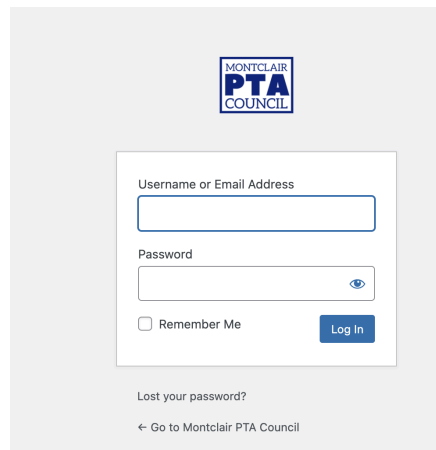
They may have the same values but they are separately administered.

Website Access

Site editing is accessed by adding /pta-login to your domain. For example, entering the following into your browser search bar:

<https://montclairpta.org/pta-login>

Brings you to a the login page as follows:

The image shows a login page for the Montclair PTA Council. At the top center is the Montclair PTA Council logo. Below it is a white login box with a blue border. Inside the box, there are two input fields: "Username or Email Address" and "Password". Below the password field is a "Remember Me" checkbox and a blue "Log In" button. Below the login box, there is a link "Lost your password?" and a link "← Go to Montclair PTA Council".

After logging in you will see your PTA home page with some additional menus across the top of it.



Most of what you need to edit your site are contained in this set of menus. These are an abbreviated list of tools from the dashboard. The dashboard is one of these menu choices and it is also accessible from the “My Sites” menu to the left of the one dropped down in the image above. Again, most of what you need is in the menu highlighted above.

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Note that an item in this drop down is “plugins”; this feature is disabled. The reason is that your site is part of a multi-site and plugins are not necessarily tested for multi-sites. Out of an abundance of caution this is not something you can add. If you need some feature, forward your request to the technology committee (technologycommittee@montclairpta.org) or bring it up in a technology committee meeting.

Fundamentally the types of functions you are most likely to need to update on your website are as follows: <<<<<<<Change the order of these to be most frequently used ones first>>>>>>

- HomePage - Separate from the Menus
- Footer - a themer layout
- Menu (Navigation)
- Posts (News)
- Specialized/Site Specific Pages
- Calendars
- Publishing, Drafts and Undoing

Each of these are discussed below.

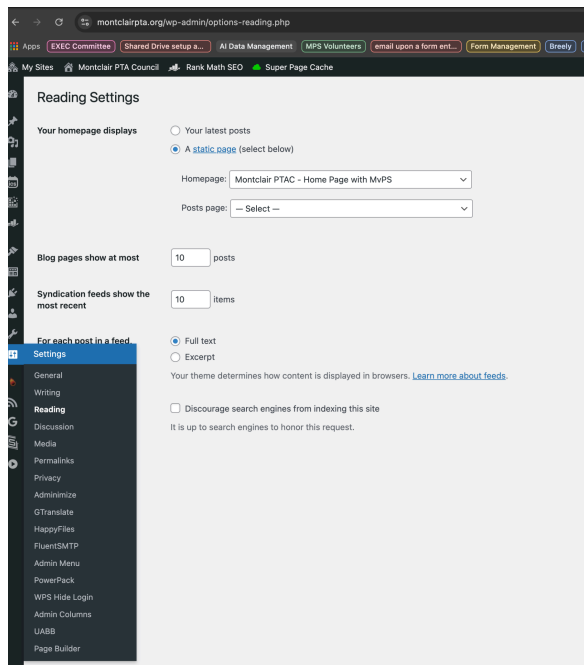
Website Home Page

The home page is created and edited like any other page and it does appear in the menu structure. However the specific page that is established in the settings. Go to the dashboard and access the settings in the vertical menu along the left hand side of the page as illustrated below.

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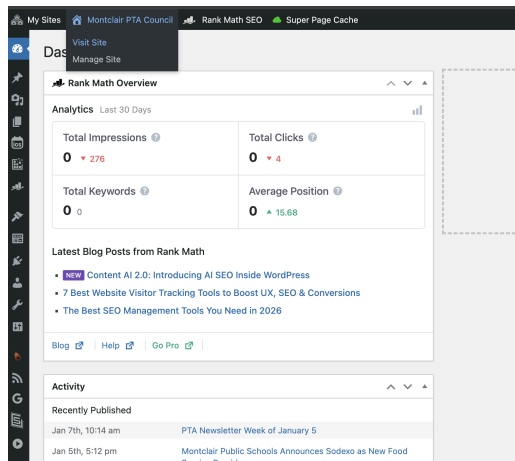
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Website Header and Footer

Modifying any formatting/styling as well as non-menu content in the header or footer is done via the page builder. Menu navigation is separate and discussed elsewhere in this document. The header and footer are accessed via the page builder but they are a special case. They are not a page per se. You gain access to them when visiting a page after you login.



there are menu choices to editing the page, header or footer

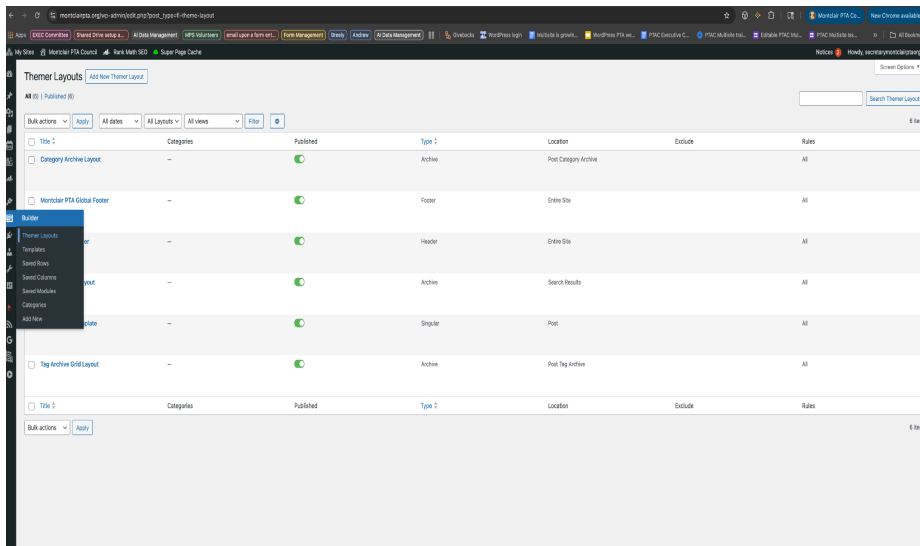
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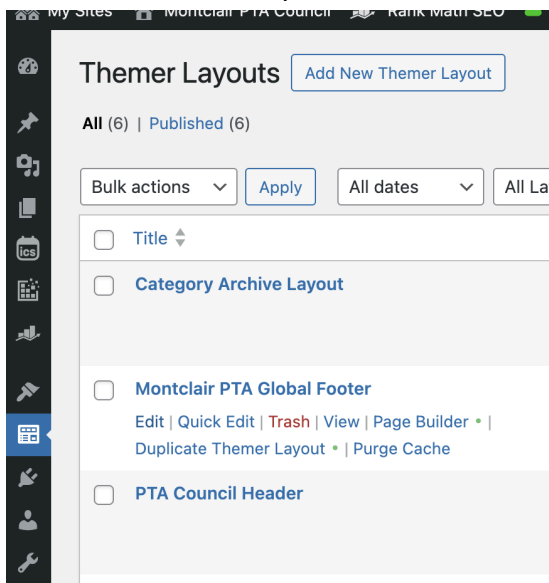
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Alternatively, the header and footer can be accessed directly via the “themer” tool which is accessed as through the dashboard as follows



Locate the entry for your PTA header or footer (The Montclair PTA Global footer in this example) and choose the edit option.



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Once you have chosen this edit option you're presented with the following (NE PTA Footer in this example)

The screenshot shows the 'Edit Themer Layout' interface. At the top, there's a breadcrumb trail: 'My Sites' > 'Northeast Elementary School PTA' > 'Rank Math SEO' > 'Super Page Cache'. Below this, the title 'Edit Themer Layout' is followed by a button 'Add New Themer Layout'. The main content area is titled 'NE PTA Footer'. Underneath, there's a 'Page Builder' section with two buttons: 'Launch Page Builder' and 'View Themer Layout'. Below that is the 'Themer Layout Settings' section, which is a table with two columns: 'Type' and 'Footer'. The 'Type' column has a dropdown menu set to 'Footer'. The 'Footer' column has a dropdown menu set to 'Entire Site'. Below the 'Entire Site' dropdown are two buttons: 'Add Location Rule' and 'Add Exclusion Rule'. At the bottom of the settings section is a 'Rules' section with a dropdown menu set to 'Add Rule Group'.

Click Launch Page Builder and you'll see the following (Montclair PTA Global Footer in this example)



GET IN TOUCH!

Montclair PTA Council
c/o Montclair Public Schools
22 Valley Road, Montclair, NJ 07042
[Email Us](#)
[Join Our Facebook Page](#)

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

[District Guide](#)
[Montclair Public Schools](#)
[New Jersey PTA Association](#)
[National PTA](#)

ABOUT US

Mrs. Ruth B. Turner
Superintendent, Montclair Public Schools
Linda Kow
President, Montclair PTA Council
Disclaimer
This site is maintained by the Montclair PTA Council and is not an official site of the Montclair School District.

Note that you can see the header but you can only edit the item you selected to edit - in the above example that is the footer. If you also want to edit the header that is done separately.

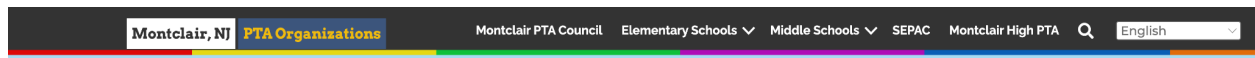
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To reiterate, modifying any formatting/styling as well as non-menu content in the header or footer is done via the page builder. Menu navigation is separate and discussed elsewhere in this document.

Regardless of how you get to editing the header, there are established formats for global navigation across the multisite which are not to be modified. Do not modify or move this portion of the header:



It is in the topmost part of the webpage. Other elements of the header, the graphics for example, you may want to change.

Once again, the site's navigation Menu also appears in the header and you may modify the appearance of it in the header but the actual navigation to different pages is controlled elsewhere. This menu navigation is described in another section of this document.

<<<<<<<<<<<<<Stopped here>>>>>>>>>>>>>

Menu (Navigation)

Posts (News) - including broadcasting stories to other sites

Making the post

Categories are queried to display posts

Broadcast - must be an Editor of the destination site Checkbox on your post

PTA/Specialized Site Specific Pages

Consider sticking home page and header/footer in here as subsections as opposed to the separate sections above??

Calendars

Social Media - sassy social

Drafts, Publishing, Undoing

Generally it is difficult to undo something – There are backups that can be used in the case of disaster and if this occurs, reach out to the technology committee. In the case of day-to-day

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edits, reverting is not something well supported. Native WordPress has this feature but if you use the page builder this is not supported.

Work in a page copy

It is best therefore to make page changes in a copy of your page and then substitute that page for the one on the site once it is reviewed and accepted. This is not to say that you cannot see what something would look like on the site before publishing it; if someone else has to see and approve the change, however, this is more awkward.

Posts are somewhat different in that they tend to be created outside of the website and then pasted into a post. If this is not the case and you are just creating a post in the editor, you can use the undo buttons and publish. You can immediately unpublish it as well.

Website - Transition/Onboarding